

Title: *In the Ashes of Time: Applying Spatial Distribution Analysis to a Burnt Layer at Satrianum (Basilicata, Italy)*

The dissertation tests a method, not a period. Spatial distribution analysis is well established in prehistoric archaeology; this study asks what it can contribute when applied instead to a medieval context, specifically sector CF 104 at *Satrianum* (Tito, Basilicata), a fortified settlement whose history extends from Norman-period development through Angevin intensification to gradual abandonment in the late medieval and early modern periods.

Corpus. Over three excavation campaigns (2022–2024), the team recorded 1,062 total-station points corresponding to 2,272 individual finds. The analysis concentrates on the collapse layer US 4008 and the underlying burnt layer US 4060. Before interpretation, spatial and stratigraphic inconsistencies were identified and checked against field documentation, with unreliable records excluded where necessary.

Method. Each find's three-dimensional position, stratigraphic unit and material category were integrated in QGIS alongside photogrammetric orthophotographs produced in Metashape and other field documentation. Density analysis, horizontal and vertical distribution mapping, moving-window counts, distance measurements and descriptive statistics were used to test spatial patterning by stratigraphic unit and material type.

Findings. The spatial evidence supports an interpretation of CF 104 as two east–west compartments, probably separated by a partition in perishable material. The eastern part is generally higher and denser, while the western part is lower and more dispersed. A deliberately clear area against the south wall in the eastern compartment may correspond to a staircase or ladder providing access from an upper level. A pit-cistern occupies much of the western compartment, while regularly spaced negative features along the interior perimeter are interpreted as possible settings for structural supports. Read together, densities, gaps, altimetric breaks and material distributions suggest that CF 104 was a multipurpose service structure, associated particularly with storage and possibly with the control of movement toward the upper part of the settlement. At a smaller scale, spatial relationships also allow cautious reconstruction of short-lived depositional events that were not readily perceptible during

excavation, including the fall of architectural elements and a possible storage fixture with associated seed scatter.

Methodological conclusion. The dissertation argues that the method's value lies less in the certainties it produces than in the questions it forces: it shifts attention from objects alone to their positions and relationships, and treats space itself as part of the formation of the archaeological record rather than as a passive container. Its limits are stated directly. Spatial interpretation depends strongly on the quality and traceability of field data; it loses power where assemblages are sparse, contexts heavily disturbed or stratigraphic relationships unclear; and rigorous recording and post-excavation processing require time, training and consistency. Spatial analysis is therefore not intended to provide certainty on its own, but to make archaeological patterns visible and generate hypotheses that can be tested against stratigraphic, taphonomic and material evidence. The study is deliberately limited to a single building and concludes by proposing comparison with other sectors of *Satrianum* as the next step.